share of its alliance with the United States – already estimated at 48 percent of the total cost[13] – and perhaps lose some or all of the US nuclear umbrella has only exacerbated concerns in Tokyo about US reliability.

India, for its part, has traditionally not relied on a close relationship with the United States for its security and therefore does not necessarily suffer similar anxieties. Only over the last decade has Delhi made significant strides toward a closer strategic partnership with Washington, to the extent of being named a “major defense partner” by the United States in June 2016 – a designation that, according to former US Secretary of Defense Ashton Carter, will facilitate “defense trade and technology sharing with [India] on a level that the United States reserves for its closest friends and allies.”[14] Moreover, as far as India’s neigh-bourhood of the Indian Ocean Region is concerned, both the United States and India are in agreement that India can and should play the role of a net security provider, which would entail a more proactive role for India’s military (especially naval) and diplomatic assets going forward. A potential US rollback of commitments in Asia therefore affects India far less than it affects Japan. To this extent, the fear of the United States abdicating leadership in Asia plagues Tokyo more than New Delhi and might explain why Japan has sought to steadily augment its strategic outreach to India in particular while the latter has adopted a multipronged approach of cultivating strategic partnerships with a range of diverse countries from France to Rwanda.[15]

Finally, Indian and Japanese leaders – as well as numerous commentators – have often highlighted the common ideological thread binding their two countries. Both countries are liberal democracies with stated commitments to upholding the rule of law, openness, and inclusive growth.[16] The assumption, at least on the Japanese side, is that shared democratic values act as the bedrock of mutual